

Paper Trail

Written by Otto Perry

CW: Some Gore (Paper/People), Family Issues/Parental Abuse

A car drives through the Nevada desert, passing by tumbleweeds and faded road signs. Mark and Nancy are sleeping in the back, with Mark's head resting on his sister's shoulder. There they have been for the past five hours on the Burrs' yearly trip to California.

"Kids! You should be awake to see the sunset; it is gorgeous!" Carol, their soon-to-be stepmother, exclaims. The kids respond with a unified groan. Spurred on by the looks he gets at the school assembly from the other parents, Mr. Burr had started dating a new woman only a year after his wife's passing. Maybe Carol participating in a family tradition would help the kids warm up to her.

"You two should be awake for when we reach Paper Trail anyway." Mr. Burr interjects, his voice shutting down any whining coming from the kids.

Nevada's Top Tourist Destinations! laid on the dashboard, with a location labeled "Paper Trail" square in the middle of the map. "*A town of the future, with technology not yet seen in the 20th century!*" was the quote used countless times to soothe the kids' dismay after the closure of the dinosaur-themed putt-putt that they had been going to for as long as Mark could walk. "I'm sure it's going to blow that dinky golf place out of the water," their father reassures them.

"But does it have dinosaurs? It doesn't sound like it has dinosaurs," Nancy responds, followed by nods of agreement between the two children.

Carol takes another drag of her cigarette, forcing Mr. Burr to crank open the window. “Not every place we visit has to include dinosaurs, you two.” Carol’s annoyance comes through in her voice, replacing her cheery facade.

While they argue, a paint-chipped sign passes by, “*Paper Trail: Population 2,*” and below that, just as faded, “*The proof is in the paper!*”

The town stood over the parked car, insignificant against the vast desert. Faded buildings with cracking skin made the fluttering sound of paper in the wind. A wooden shack labeled *Parking* sits at the edge of the town, facing the road leading out of town.

As the car pulls in, Carol says, “Well, your father and I are going to look over our directions again. Why don’t you two go look around?”

“But don’t you want to see the place?” Nancy asks while leaning up into the front of the car.

Mr. Burr opens his mouth, but he is interrupted by Carol. “No, it’s for you kids to go explore and for mommy to read *Cosmopolitan*.” She side-eyes him, “And daddy will stay in the car with me,” she continues, “And make sure to keep Mark happy.” She scrunches her nose at Nancy before shooing them out of the car.

They walked towards the center of the town, passing by the cartoonish facades of an old-western jail and saloon, which contrasted with the gallows situated directly in the center of the town, all of which were tied together by being completely made of paper.

“Future technology, my butt!” Nancy pats her brother on the shoulder. “This town just looks like a more rundown version of those cowboy shows we watch together.”

“Yea...” he says, letting his head down. “Nancy, do you think our new mommy doesn’t like us?”

“Oh...” Nancy is silent for a moment. A tumbleweed passes in front of them. “No, no, she doesn’t, Mark; she just hasn’t had much time to get to know you. Know us! I mean, it was only last year that Dad introduced us to her.” Nancy nods her head, her face scrunching up. “She’s the only mommy you have.”

“That’s not true though!” Mark’s grip tightens, and they both stop in place. “You were there when that weird clown got too close to me at the fair and when those kids were gonna steal my drawings.” He wraps his arms around Nancy and says, “You’ve been looking out for me like mommy would have! I know you will always protect me from scary stuff, forever and ever... and you don’t make the house smell like smoke.”

Nancy wraps her arms around Mark. “I promise that I’ll always protect you, especially from the scary stuff. Forever and ever.”

As Nancy wiped the tears from her eyes, she spotted a building on the other side of the gallows. It bore the face of an older man, his gray hair depicted like rays of sunshine. “*Meet The*

Creator!” read above the man’s face. The old man reminded them of Frankenstein, for Nancy, the scientist, and for Mark, the reanimated monster.

“Hey Mark, maybe we should go see the only person in town over there. Unless he died of old age,” Mark frowns, and she nervously chuckles, “or boredom.”

She leads Mark towards the building by hand. Mark does little to protest except to squeeze Nancy’s hand tighter.

They open the door, and a waft of warm air carries with it a stench of paper, glue, and something else they couldn’t parse. The walls are comprised of peeling wallpaper that only reveals more paper underneath, and the floor beneath their feet is compressed with dry rot. They soon come across a hallway with a single door at the end.

“Nancy, can we please go back, please?” Mark pleads as they step closer and closer to a door ajar at the end of the hallway. Peeling portraits, pool paint onto the floor as they get closer to the door. Nancy’s curiosity had to be satisfied.

When they open the door, they see an intricate bedroom. At a glance, it was clear that this room was once a masterpiece, with every hanging photo or cabinet knob created out of paper. However, rot and decay show a lack of maintenance, with the paper sheets peeling off the bed like wallpaper.

In the corner, a man sits facing away from them. Nancy begins to walk towards him. “Sir, are you ok?” Nancy asks with only the whistling through the crumpled window as a response.

“Don’t touch him!” Mark cries out too late, as Nancy pulls on the man’s shoulder. The chair spins around, and she sees the face from the mural in a cold grimace, his hands lightly clasping his guts as they stain the floor a deep red.

“Close your eyes, Mark. Close them!” she yells as she drags him back towards the hallway. They both run down the hallway, dust and ripped pieces of paper filling the air with each step. Before they can leave, she bumps into a tall figure standing in the doorway. Looking up, they see a set of jumbled paper tubes hanging from a ripped dress. Only after seeing the figure’s painted eyes and blood-slicked hands reaching for them did they dash in the other direction, pursued by heavy footsteps.

The two kids book it back into the bedroom and scramble underneath the bed, watching the thing enter the room. Mark begins to open his mouth as tears begin to stream down his face, before Nancy covers it. Thudding footsteps leave imprints on the floor as the creature limps only a few feet away from their faces. Its paper guts flop onto the floor, and the noise of them scraping against the ground reminds Nancy of the newspaper runs she does back home. Once the creature stomps over to the other side of the room, she books it from under the bed, heading towards the door. Her death grip on Mark’s arm causes him to yell, causing the thudding to follow right behind them.

Nancy burst out of the door running faster than she had ever run before, with Mark straddling her back as he held on for dear life. She spots the car to her right, next to an exit sign eroded by the elements. She tries to turn, but the thing grabs Mark’s shoulder. As Nancy turns around, the sound of ripping paper fills the air as starchy paste and blood are smeared on Mark’s back. One of the thing’s wet claws hits the ground with a plop as it cries out in muffled groans.

The two kids run to the parking barn and practically jump into the backseat of the car, quickly rolling up their windows.

“Drive! Go! Go!” Nancy yells at her father, banging on his headrest.

“Please!” Mark begs, his face red and wet with tears.

“What the hell happened?” Carol interrogates, “Did you get Mark hurt?” Carol touches the red paste mixture on Mark’s back and says, “Jesus Christ! How did this happen? I asked you to keep him safe, and now he’s crying.”

“We can talk about it later, Carol.” Mr. Burr tries to intervene, but Carol raises her voice.

“Don’t you dare put your foot on that pedal! What kind of man lets his children control him? I didn’t know how much you needed-“Carol’s rant is cut off when her hair is grabbed by a paper claw.

The car is filled with everyone’s screams as Carol is pulled out of the car through the window. Mr. Burr puts his foot on the pedal, busting open the closed barn door in front of the car.

Through the rear window, the kids turn to see a claw pulling the barn door closed, flesh blood dripping over chipping paint.

Star Watching

By Otto Perry

CW: Use of a homophobic slur

I walked into my new office for the first time. The smooth walls reflected and cast pink light across the room, curving inward to create the floor. My superior shows me my desk, covered in buttons and screens, from which I'd create my battle plans. In front of the desk was a view of the city of Zipet, military vehicles mixed in with Tuk-Tuks and bicycles. Past the bustling city are dusty reds and pinks that seem to stretch on forever.

The sun was setting, well, the sun I saw was setting. Just as one sun set in the west, another rose in the east. The only stars I have ever seen.

I stood there, taking the view in before I was interrupted by an over-enthusiastic pat on the back. He agreed that the view was beautiful and joked that I shouldn't get too deep into my thoughts, since I have an important job to do. The view was not on my mind as he left the room, as my lover's face projected over the desert's pinks and reds.

That was three years ago. Three years went by in a blur of battle plans and toasts to the settlements we took back, and the squadrons destroyed. I smiled during those moments, not because I wanted to, but because I had to. Company policy.

Dewen, my lover, was stationed a galaxy away. Bureaucracy and patriotism put a galaxy between us. It was only through written letters that I was able to communicate with my love. I always enjoyed the written word.

At least we could talk, I would tell myself, but I yearned for his presence. My imagination is a poor replica of the feeling of his arms wrapped around my chest, or how his smile could brighten up my whole day.

At that moment, I'm back to when we first met. He was working at my favorite restaurant, where they served these fried dough things with locally made cheese inside of them. It wasn't a place someone from my family would enjoy, a long line of military commanders and leaders with even longer sticks up their asses. But I loved the food, so I would go eat there when I got my monthly allowance. The last time I went there, three years ago, Dewen was the one who took my order. As he stood there, a smile on his face, I couldn't help but be drawn to him. He looked so confident, so cool. I can remember my face becoming flushed as I had all these new feelings, all for someone I just met. My father would tell me that I had to look for a respectable woman at the same level as my family and me, but all I wanted at that moment was to get to know this guy, no matter if he was respected or not. As I'm getting caught up in that memory, the door buzzer rings.

"Mail for you." Muffles from the other side of the door, and an envelope falls through the slot.

If there's one thing the Ricite Corporation appreciates, it's 20th-century shit like physical letters. I wasn't too quick to complain, however, as when I picked up the letter, I noticed it was from my sweet Dewen. My increased heartbeat and nervous fingers reminded me of the romantic novelty of a letter sent a galaxy away.

My mind is taken back to that moment three years ago, standing there at the counter as sweat formed on my face. I'm surprised when he takes my hand.

"Hey, don't worry, I get this kind of reaction a lot." He said to me.

“Really?” I asked, enjoying his hand on mine.

“No, not really, I just said that to make me less afraid of what I’m feeling right now,” I remember feeling his hand trembling as he held my hand.

I had never heard anything more relatable before.

Mind full of memories, I went to open it before something stole my breath. The red seal that held the company’s insignia was peeling back a smidge as if someone tried to press it back on.

Oh my god.

Jeremy, the person assigned to inspect my mail and who would be deemed the necessary sacrifice if somebody sent me a bomb, was the only person who could have opened the letter.

The rank of commander comes with the perk of increased privacy, Jeremy being the only other soul that touched my letters.

As I paced toward his office, thoughts raced through my mind. *What if he has already told them?*

What if my supervisor is already leaning over his desk as Jeremy whispers about our relationship? Thinking about it made my pace increase. My speed-walking past the cubicles did not ease the tension in the place where the war was being waged, but at that moment, I was fighting my own battle.

I almost ran into the blast-resistant door to his room, fumbling the lock open before I burst through. Jeremy is there, typing on his computer, a look of shock on his face. I’m frozen for a second.

Does he even know? Am I just being paranoid?

“Heyyyyyy, Jeremy, just checking in on ya.” I push the door closed behind me, finding the latch and locking the door without looking. “You’ve been doing a great job lately.” I was already starting to regret this reconnaissance mission, just barging into another person’s room.

“Oh, thanks for checking in. I haven’t blown up yet, as you can obviously see.” He chuckles, the scars and burn marks around his face reminding me had been blown up before, but not bad enough to get moved to another department. Another reason for me to just turn around and leave him alone.

“Welp, that’s good... I’m going to leave now.”

I fire weak finger guns at him as I turn to leave the room. As I was turning the latch, I heard Jeremy mumble something.

“...in love with a footsoldier...”

I twist my head back. “What did you say, Jeremy?” He leans back, his mouth shifting back into a smile. “Did you open the letter you just delivered? You know that lying about that kind of thing might cost you your job, or your life, or both.” I used my position against him, I must admit, and it's not something I’m proud of.

He tenses his shoulders, leaning over his desk as his brows furrow. “Yes, I did, Onyx. Because you’re my friend,” he sighs, “I want to help you keep your job. You can’t have your head in the clouds for some pretty-boy footsoldier. He went one way, and you went another way for a reason. You’re a one-in-a-generation commander, so I’m going to help you pull your head out of your ass. As you know, threatening someone’s job can really motivate them.” His mouth slowly formed into a grin.

I stopped listening after he mentioned Dewen. All I could see was red.

“You fucker.” I pressed my hands onto his desk, knocking over the Newton’s Cradle on his desk.

“Just because you call me a friend does not mean you get to *blackmail* me into breaking up with him. Haven’t I had enough taken away from me? My free time, my energy, and now the love of my life? You are not going to be the one who keeps me from him.”

He stood still, his eyes lined up with mine. “I’m not scared of some queer playing war, wearing his pink shoulderpa- “

Before he’s finished, I’m gripping him with both hands by his collar, “If you tell anyone about Dewen and me, the first person in your barracks to put a grenade under your *fucking* pillow is getting a promotion.” I must admit, my gross abuse of power may have crossed the line, but looking back, I think he mostly deserved it.

He slinks back in his chair, sweat building on his brow. “Are we clear?” I practically hissed through clenched teeth. He nods, and I nod back. What felt like only a few moments later I was back in my office, the setting and rising suns deepening the red shades of my office. I slump into my chair, noticing that I still have Dewen’s letter in my suit pocket.

The week we were together, Dewen would sneak into my house every single night so we could hang out and talk. We couldn’t date in public; hell, we couldn’t even hold hands if we wanted to. My parents would disown me if they found out I was, one, dating a guy, two, dating a guy who had nowhere to live and served cheesy fried dough for a living. We didn’t think that we would have to keep it a secret for too long, but that changed when news of the draft came.

After I heard the news, I ran to the restaurant, but it was closed, and there was a long line of people down the block. They were the poor, standing in line for their mandatory assignment into

the military. I looked for Dewen, and I found him near the front of the line. I rushed towards him, but he put his hand out, stopping me in my tracks.

“Just let me go, Onyx. You have done more for me in a week than anyone has done in my life. You have better things to attend to.” He said, turning away before advancing further in line.

I ran up to him, and I whispered, “I will find a way, I promise. I will write to you.”

He nodded, a smile underneath his tears, and at that moment, I wanted to kiss him more than anything else. But I couldn't.

I took the letter out, carefully peeled back the seal, and opened the envelope. I unfolded the tiny piece of standard-issue paper that can only hold a few sentences.

For my star Onyx,

I hope getting to be the big man in charge isn't putting too much pressure on you. I worry about you even though we have no shelter currently. The thought of you rescuing me from this place keeps me going. I look for you out in the stars.

Love, Dewen

Only when I stopped reading did I notice that tears began to stain the piece of paper. I quickly attempted to wipe off my tears from the page, but it just left wet marks. I cried because he had gone through so much, so much more than I ever have.

But then I smiled knowing that someday we'd both be watching the stars together.